WATCHLIST

THE PLOTS THICKEN

Hindi films and shows to stream this December



FREDDY

DISNEY+ HOTSTAR, *(December 2)*

Kartik Aaryan suggests that Dr Freddy Ginwala, the dentist he plays, got under his skin. With his maniacal grin and the sinister solitude seen in the trailer, we can guess why.



CAT

NETFLIX, *(December 9)*

Set in Punjab, this show follows Gurneet Singh (Randeep Hooda), an ex-police informant, who must relearn the tricks of his old trade when his brother finds himself on the wrong side of the law.



FAADU

SONYLIV, *(December 9)*

Starring Pavail Gulati and Saiyami Kher, this series tells a love story where opposites attract. Abhay and Manjiri are both poets, but will Manjiri's equanimity be an antidote to Abhay's ambition?

FILM

Always a Hero

Even while playing the villain, Jaideep Ahlawat gives his character the importance of a protagonist

Releasing on December 2, *An Action Hero* sees Jaideep Ahlawat essay a part, which, according to him, is in his blood. Bhoora Solanki, a wrestler-turned-municipal councillor, is from Mandothi village in Haryana. Ahlawat's own ancestral home in Kharkara is some 50 km away. "If somebody tells you to play yourself, that can be tricky," he says. "But I get what Bhoora is trying to say and his sense of humour. He doesn't intend it to be funny." Going by the trailer, all of Ahlawat's punchlines seem to land with a sardonic echo.

Though the film marks Ahlawat's return to the big screen after over a year, the actor has used that time to build the reputation of a powerhouse performer. There was, of course, his iconic portrayal of Hathiram Chaudhary, the honest police officer in *Paatal Lok* (2020–), but there was also his equally compelling turn as the TRP-hungry TV anchor Deepankar Sanyal in *The Broken News* (2022–). Ahlawat, though, admits to missing the big screen. It does, after all, have "its own charm". It was in cinemas that Ahlawat first made an impression, playing the no-nonsense trainer to Alia Bhatt's rookie spy in *Raazi* (2018). "During [*Raazi*], I felt my acting software was upgraded. I fell in love with my craft more," he says. But *Paatal Lok*, his first big project as a central character, was the "out-and-out gamechanger". Released during the lockdown, the industry and audiences took a shine to him. "Hathiram had all the *navarasas* [nine emotions mentioned in the Natyashastra]," he says. "The writers and directors felt that 'if you give him something, he will make it his own'."

Getting lead parts, once a challenge, now feels routine. That is how he views *An Action Hero*, in which he plays the nemesis to Ayushmann Khurrana. "I don't play a villain as a villain; I play him like a hero. If I don't, his natural *bhava* won't come across."

> For Ahlawat, Paatal Lok, his first big project as a central character, was a 'game changer'

A self-confessed "introvert", Ahlawat doesn't have a publicist. His lessons in self-promotion are incremental—he recently learned how to attach a link to an Instagram story. But the upgrading of his thespian prowess is a whole other story. Streaming, also, has ensured that he has few failures. Ahlawat often finds his name clubbed with artists like Manoj Bajpayee, Pankaj Tripathi and his FTII batchmate Vijay Varma, whose popularity seems rooted in their acting skills. "Audiences want to see actors, be it OTT or the big screen," he says.

Ahlawat recently wrapped a Netflix film, an adaptation of the popular suspense novel *Devotion of Suspect X*, with Kareena Kapoor Khan. Before he sinks into second seasons of *Paatal Lok* and *The Broken News*, an independent drama somewhat quietly added itself to his filmography. *Three of Us*, starring Shefali Shah and Swanand Kirkire, was recently screened at IFFI Goa. Heroes, clearly, have no time to waste. ■

Suhani Singh

